

ABC & Case Study Research – Practice Exam Q&A;

(English + ■■■■■)

Part I – Exam Questions (≈ 40 min total)

1■■ Describe the ABC Framework (Actors–Behavior–Context). Explain how the eight research strategies fit within it and the trade■■offs they represent.

2■■■ What does the statement 'Seek generalizability over responses, not over the population of actors' mean in the ABC framework?

3■■ Explain the four main types of validity (construct ■■■■, internal ■■■■, external ■■■■, reliability ■■) and how they relate to case study research.

4. Outline the main types of case study research (theory building, theory testing, problem solving) and their goals.

5 ■ Summarize the five major steps of designing and conducting a case study (design, prepare, collect, analyze, report ■■■■■■■■■■).

6■■ According to Flyvbjerg (2006), list and briefly explain the five common misunderstandings about case study research (■■ / ■■).

Part II – Model Answers (■■■■■ with Key Chinese terms)

1■■■ ABC Framework: Axes = Actors (■■■), Behavior (■■), Context (■■). Research strategies are classified by **obtrusiveness** (■■■■) and **generalizability** (■■■■). Eight strategies: Field Study, Field Experiment, Experimental Simulation, Laboratory Experiment, Judgment Study, Sample Study, Formal Theory, Computer Simulation. Trade-off: cannot maximize realism, precision & generalizability simultaneously.

2■■■ Meaning: Generalizability over responses means focus on whether patterns of behavior or relationships would recur under similar conditions, not on representing all possible actors. In SE research we aim for **analytical generalization** (■■■■) not statistical sampling of people.

3■■■ Validity: **Construct** (■■■■) – measure what we intend. **Internal** (■■■■) – control confounders to establish causality. **External** (■■■■) – ability to generalize to other contexts or actors. **Reliability** (■■) – replicability by other researchers. In case studies, triangulation (■■■■) strengthens all four.

4■■■ Case Study Types: **Theory Building** (■■■■) – inductive exploration, discover new concepts (Eisenhardt 1989). **Theory Testing** (■■■■) – structured, deductive validation (Yin 2003). **Problem Solving** (■■■■) – practical, stakeholder-oriented (Van de Ven 2007). Each type differs in goal and interaction with theory.

5■■■ Case Study Steps: 1 Design – define objectives & case selection. 2 Prepare – protocol for data collection (■■■■). 3 Collect – multiple sources (interviews, observations, metrics). 4 Analyze – qualitative + quantitative triangulation (■■■■). 5 Report – transparent presentation of findings ↔ data.

6■■■ Five Misunderstandings (Flyvbjerg 2006):

- 1 Practical knowledge < Theoretical – ■ both valuable.
- 2 Cannot generalize from 1 case – ■ can via analytical generalization.
- 3 Only for hypothesis generation – ■ also for testing and refinement.
- 4 Bias toward verification – ■ protocols and triangulation reduce bias.
- 5 Hard to summarize – ■ rich context gives depth not weakness.